

The seeds are harvested when ripe and dried in the sun.

**Parts Used** Seeds.

**Constituents** Kola nut contains up to 2.5% caffeine (generally higher than coffee), theobromine, tannins, phlobaphene, and an anthocyanin.

**History & Folklore** Chewed for their digestive, tonic, and aphrodisiac properties, kola nuts have been an integral part of western and central African life for thousands of years. Kola nuts are used in huge quantities today to flavor soft drinks.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Kola nut stimulates the central nervous system and the body as a whole. It increases alertness and muscular strength, counters lethargy, and has been used extensively both in western African and Anglo-American herbal medicine as an antidepressant, particularly during recovery from chronic illness. Like coffee (*Coffea arabica*, preceding entry), kola is used to treat headaches and migraine. It is diuretic and astringent, and may be taken for diarrhea and dysentery.

**Related Species** *C. nitida*, which grows in Africa, Brazil, and the West Indies, is used in the same fashion.

**Cautions** Do not take if suffering from high blood pressure, peptic ulcers, or palpitations.



*Meadow saffron is an attractive yet highly toxic herb, requiring great caution in usage. It is a well-established remedy for treating gout.*

## *Colchicum autumnale* (Liliaceae) Meadow Saffron

**Description** Attractive perennial growing from a bulb-like corm to 4 in (10 cm). Has pointed lance-shaped leaves and tubular 6-petaled pink flowers in autumn.

**Habitat & Cultivation** Common in Europe and North Africa, meadow saffron grows wild in woods and damp meadows. It is also cultivated. The corm is gathered in early summer; the seeds in late summer.

**Parts Used** Corm, seeds.

**Constituents** Meadow saffron contains alkaloids (including colchicine) and flavonoids. Colchicine is anti-inflammatory and is used in conventional medicine for acute attacks of gout. As it affects cell division it can cause fetal abnormality. It has been used in the laboratory to create new genetic strains.

**History & Folklore** Meadow saffron was not used in classical times due to its poisonous nature. Arabian physicians used it in the Middle Ages to treat joint pain and gout, but otherwise herbalists disregarded the plant until the 19th century.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Despite its toxicity, meadow saffron is considered one of the best remedies for acute gout pain. Leukemia has

been successfully treated with meadow saffron, and the plant has also been used with some success to treat Behcet's syndrome, a chronic disease marked by recurring ulcers and leukemia. Taken internally, the herb has significant side effects even at low dosage. Externally, it is applied to relieve neuralgia and itchiness.

☠️ ⚠️ **Cautions** This herb is highly toxic. Use only under professional supervision. Do not use during pregnancy. Meadow saffron is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

## *Collinsonia canadensis* (Lamiaceae) Stone Root

**Description** Perennial herb growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has a square stem, oval leaves, and clusters of greenish-yellow flowers.

**Habitat & Cultivation** This herb is native to moist woodlands of eastern North America. The root is dug up in autumn.

**Parts Used** Root, leaves.

**Constituents** Stone root contains a volatile oil, tannins, and saponins.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Stone root has diuretic and tonic properties, and is chiefly employed in the treatment of kidney stones. It is also prescribed to counteract fluid retention. It has

been used to reduce back pressure in the veins, which in turn helps prevent the formation or worsening of hemorrhoids and varicose veins. As an astringent, stone root contracts the inner lining of the intestines, and can be helpful in treating disorders of the digestive system such as irritable bowel syndrome and mucous colitis. The fresh leaves or roots of stone root are applied as a poultice to bruises and sores.

## *Commiphora mukul* (Burseraceae) Guggul

**Description** Spiny shrub or tree, growing to 6½ ft (2 m), with oval, serrated leaves, brownish-red flowers, and red fruits. Guggul, the gum resin obtained from the bark, forms pale yellow to brown "tears" on the stems.

**Habitat & Cultivation** Guggul thrives in dry, semi-arid and desert environments across much of the Indian sub-continent and the Middle East.

**Parts Used** Gum resin.

**Constituents** Guggul is an oleo-gum resin, its main active constituents being fat-soluble steroids (guggulipids), in particular guggulsterones E and Z.

**History & Folklore** Early Ayurvedic texts describe guggul as being effective in treating obesity. This has led to research into whether the gum resin might be useful for problems associated with fat metabolism, such as raised blood cholesterol levels.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Guggul has anti-inflammatory, blood-thinning, and cholesterol-lowering activity, and—true to ancient understanding of the herb—can be helpful in treating obesity. In Ayurveda, guggul is principally used to treat arthritic problems, such as osteoarthritis, though it is also considered to have tonic and rejuvenating properties. As a result of research in the 1980s and 1990s, guggul is now most commonly used to lower raised blood cholesterol levels and to improve blood fat profiles in general. It reduces the stickiness of platelets and thins the blood, and may have a protective activity on the heart. Guggul is also useful in the treatment of acne. The normal dose of guggulipid extract is 1–1.5 g a day (equivalent to 50–75 mg of guggulsterones).

**Research** Extensive research has shown that the guggulipids have anti-inflammatory and antiarthritic activity and prevent or reverse raised blood cholesterol levels. In several clinical trials, patients showed an average fall in cholesterol levels of about 12%, and in triglycerides of about 14%. The overall blood-fat profile was also shown to improve. Some clinical trials recorded weight loss for patients taking guggulipids.

**Caution** Avoid if breastfeeding.